

PUBLISHER PITCH · 2026

ZARNITSA

“The oath binds the vataga. The vataga holds the world. Betray the oath — and the world falls first.”

Narrative action-RPG · Single-player + co-op 2–4 · PC / next-gen consoles / cloud · Release 2031

Vataga Games

LOGLINE

The god is dead. Night is coming. The Vataga remembers.

Thirty years ago, people killed the last god — Zlatoglav. Since then the Mgla rises from the earth each night, and the country grows rich digging gold out of his body. Every ingot unearthed brings the eternal night closer. The player is the Oathbound Ataman, leading a vataga of sworn brothers: six companions with their own memory, hidden agendas and a very real capacity for betrayal.

Memory of the brotherhood

choices stay in every companion's memory

A world worth preparing for

victory is earned before the battle: scouting, oils, the hour you march

Morality without a judge

no good-and-evil meter, only consequences that ripen

The night as an element

trade and politics by day, survival by night



100+
hours of content

6
companions with memory

5
regions of Okovye

4
global endings

SECTION 01 / 03

01 THE GAME

The world of Okovye, the vataga, and the Betrayal Engine

UNIQUE SELLING POINT

Companions who remember everything

In existing RPGs, companions are either eternal, or their attitude shifts by a single number, or they betray on script. In Zarnitsa, betrayal is a simulation: every companion carries a memory journal, a personal rupture threshold and a goal pursued even off-screen. The game continuously checks three conditions, and when they converge, the companion acts against the ataman — from sabotaging gear to a Night of Knives.

Memory journal

four kinds of tags: honor · blood · gold · faith

Personal threshold

five irreversible stages: from first doubt to the Night of Knives

Circumstance node

accumulated grudge, opportunity and incentive must converge at once

The Witcher 3 — set-dressing companions

Baldur's Gate 3 — no life outside the party

Dragon Age — one approval number

ZARNITSA — betrayal as a simulation








6 companions × 5 stages × 4 endings — a matrix you cannot see in a single playthrough



SETTING

Okovye: a country living on the body of a god

Dark Slavic fantasy with no orcs and no elves: the nav, the Oathbound, rumor-mongering taverns and the Gilded Decree. By day Okovye trades, litigates and weaves politics; by night the world belongs to the Mgla. The player chooses the hour of leaving camp — and pays for the choice.

- **5 regions** — from the Polesie marshes to the drowned Still Sea
- **The Mgla** — the world's tension meter: gold dug from the god's body brings the eternal night closer

SIX FACTIONS

- Oathbound Vatagas
- Gilded Decree
- Seer Circles
- Courts of Nav
- Princes' Council
- Children of Dawn

BESTIARY OF THE NAV

Mglenik · Uporen · Kostyanitsa · Zarnik · Mgla-Vedun

GAMEPLAY LOOP

Contract → Camp → Night

1

CONTRACT

A job board with bargaining: price, deadlines, currency, witnesses. Terms shift in dialogue — witnesses remember the deal, and a stingy haggle comes back through a companion's memory journal.

→

2

CAMP

One conversation before nightfall: the raid party — up to three brothers; gear: oils, traps, strings. Gifts and oaths stay in the vataga's memory.

→

3

NIGHT

A real-time raid into the Mgla under the Oath Pause. After the fight — the Right of Speech: a brother may step out of the shadow with a grievance, and the ataman answers.

Between nights the world lives without the player: factions make their moves, rumors spread through taverns, the Mgla gathers strength.

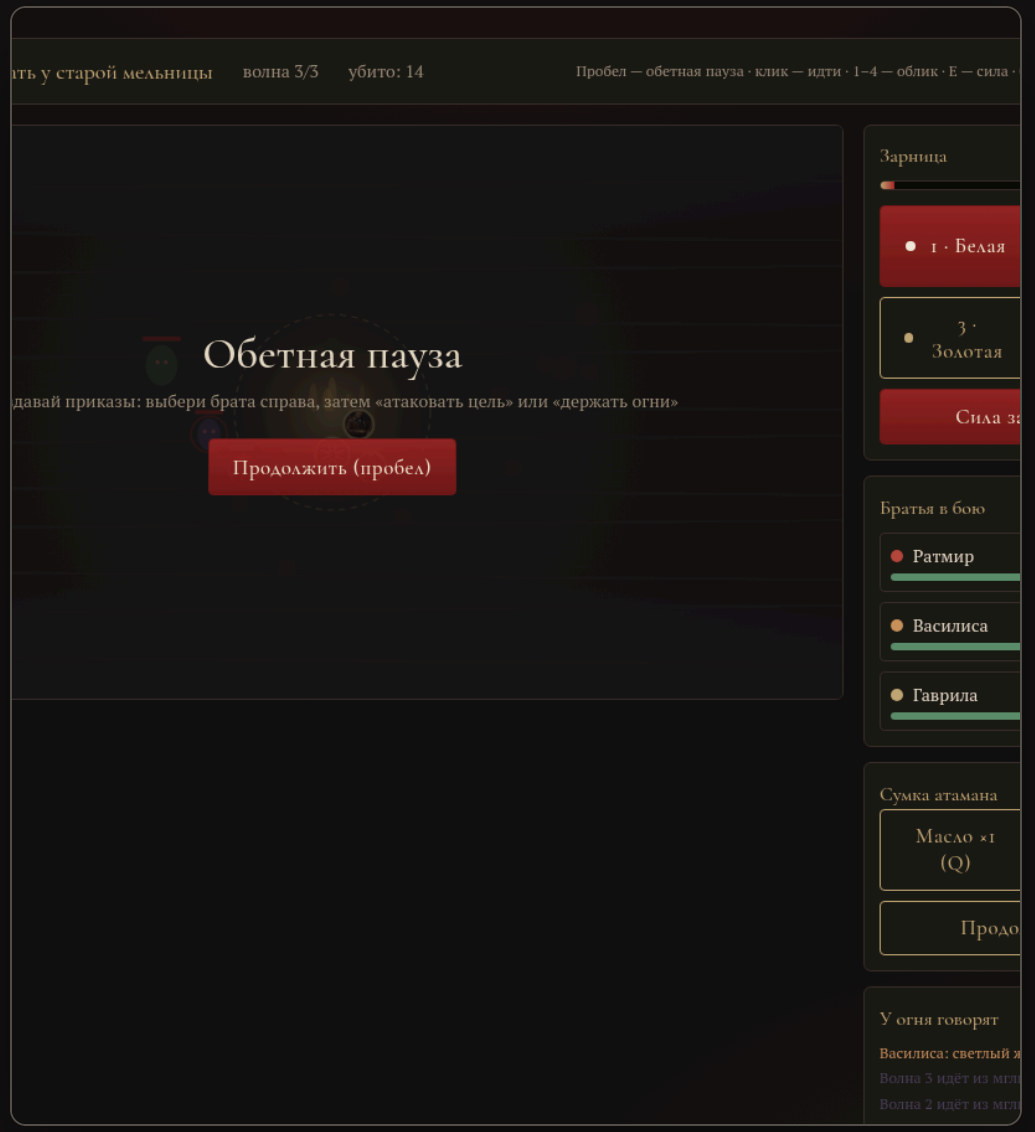
COMBAT SYSTEM

Real time under the Oath Pause

The spacebar freezes time at any moment: the ataman issues orders to the brothers, picks a Zaritsa form and resumes the fight. Reflex matters less than half an hour of preparation — “run in and swing” tactics are punished naturally.

- **1 · White** — five empowered strikes in a row
- **2 · Blue** — a slowing field around the point of the throw
- **3 · Gold** — shield and healing for the whole vataga
- **4 · Red** — detonates the accumulated Mgla across the causeway

Heat and overload: every form heats the power — in overload, strikes burn your own. Oathfire holds the line: the nav skirt the flame in a wide arc.



Prototype: the Oath Pause, orders to the brothers and four Zaritsa forms

THE VATAGA

The six who can betray



Ratmir

WARDEN · FRONTLINE DEFENSE

"Leads the brothers away if the vataga is sacrificed for profit"



Vasilisa

SEERESS · HEAT SUPPORT

"Defects to the Seer Circles if the vault is razed"



Gavrila

MARKSMAN · LOGISTICS

"Sells the ataman's plans for gold"



Khodata

PACTMAKER · CONTROL

"Joins the Courts of Nav after a massacre of the nav"



Odinets

ARCHER · SCOUTING

"An engineered heresy: a separate story branch"



Miluta

CHANTER · CHRONICLER

"A slanderous chronicle against the ataman"

Each memory holds four kinds of tags: **honor · blood · gold · faith.** Tags move a companion up the rupture ladder — from doubt to the Night of Knives.

CO-OP

Raids for 2–4 that stay in the chronicle

A hybrid without compromise: the single-player campaign carries the narrative, while co-op raids are assembled from day contracts and play out in the night layer. Cross-play across all platforms from day one. A raid is preserved as a “line” in both players’ chronicles — co-op doesn’t discard the story, it writes into it.

×8

how many times better a typical co-op game sells than a non-co-op on Steam: about **40,000 copies** versus **5,000** (VGI · Sensor Tower)

Launch goal: at least 18% of players complete at least one raid.



SECTION 02 / 03

02 MARKET

Audience, competitors and the sales model

AUDIENCE & DEMAND

A proven market, an open niche

The core is players aged 20–40 who grew up on The Witcher 3 and Baldur's Gate 3: story, choices, long campaigns. The secondary segment is streamers: every vataga has its own betrayal, and every Night of Knives is a ready-made broadcast.

50+ million

The Witcher 3: the benchmark of story-driven RPGs

20+ million

Baldur's Gate 3 as of December 2025 (Bloomberg)

30 million

It Takes Two: the co-op phenomenon; Hazelight's catalog tops 50 million (A Way Out 13M, Split Fiction 7M)

100K

in 3 weeks — Black Book: demand for a Slavic setting (Morteshka, 2021)

> *The "adult dark fantasy with companions" niche is open now that Dragon Age has moved on to multiplayer experiments.*

COMPETITIVE POSITIONING

We take the combination, and keep the niche

GAME	STRENGTH	WHAT'S MISSING	OUR ANSWER
The Witcher 3	Dense quests, adult moral dilemmas	Companions are set dressing, betrayal is scripted	**Companions are the core of the simulation**
Baldur's Gate 3	Freedom of choice, reputation	The world doesn't live outside the party; no autonomous goals	**Companion goals execute off-screen**
Dragon Age	Character ensemble, banter	A single approval number; ruptures are cosmetic	**Five irreversible stages of rupture**
Kingdom Come 2	Simulation of preparation and daily life	No party mechanics, no story-driven vataga	**Preparation + ensemble in one loop**

World scale — CD Projekt RED. Simulation density — Larian. Ensemble drama — BioWare. The memory and betrayal of comrades — ours alone.

SALES MODEL

Premium pricing, long life cycle

$69.99
base game price

PC · consoles · cloud
release platforms

Cross-play
one pool from day one

LIFE CYCLE

MONTH 4

“Winter Oaths”

free patch campaign

MONTH 10

DLC “Children of Dawn”

the next chapter of the vataga’s arc

MONTH 20

DLC “The Still Deep”

the sunken layer of the Still Sea

9M copies
year-one plan

20M
life-cycle plan

5.2M
break-even point (net price $42)

- Completion ≥ 38 % · Sessions 75+ minutes · Reach rupture stage IV ≥ 55% · Co-op players ≥ 18 % · Press 85+ -

SECTION 03 / 03

03 THE DEAL

Prototype, production plan, budget and terms

READINESS

The vertical slice is already playable

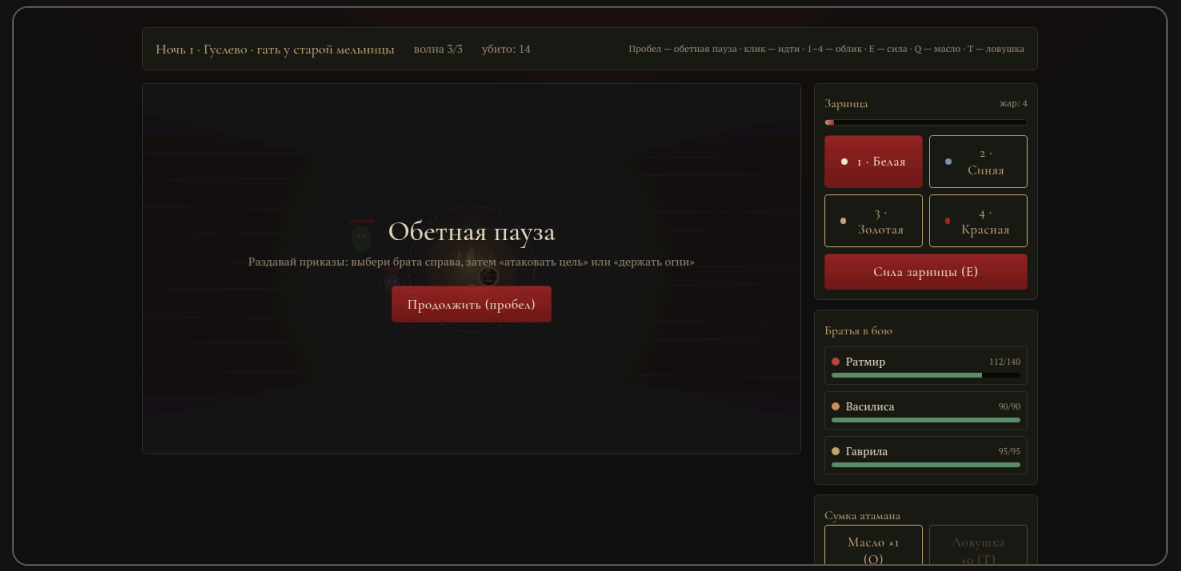
ZARNITSA · Three Nights is a working prototype of the core: three days and three nights, all four systems in one build. Real time with the Oath Pause and four Zaritsa forms; the companions' rupture ladder from doubt to the Night of Knives; the Right of Speech after battle; factions, gold and the Mgla as world-scale resources.

- ✦ Full golden path verified: title → contracts → three nights → finale
- ✦ Three finales across three lines of ataman behavior
- ✦ Six companions with memory, tags and the Right of Speech

Build link and the full GDD (30 pages) — available on request.



Camp: the vataga's memory, conversation and raid lineup



Night: the Oath Pause, orders and four Zaritsa forms

PRODUCTION PLAN

Five years, five phases — $210M

2027
PRE-PRODUCTION
vertical slice: Polesie, combat, vataga memory

90–120 staff

2028
PRODUCTION I
two regions, full bestiary, Betrayal Engine v1

240–300 staff

2029
PRODUCTION II
all five regions, voiced story skeleton, co-op alpha

360–420 staff

2030
ALPHA & BETA
content lock, balancing, co-op beta, localization

420–450 staff

2031
RELEASE
optimization, certification, marketing campaign

400 → 150 staff

BUDGET: $210M



A dedicated team of 14 has been building the Betrayal Engine since day one — the project's riskiest and most valuable system.

THE ASK

What we are asking for

Financing of full production — **$210 million**, staged across the 2027–2031 phases. The publisher leads marketing, distribution and certification; the studio owns narrative and the Betrayal Engine.

Vataga Games studio

220 full-time specialists by mid-production

28	46	60	70	16
narrative	design	programming	art	QA & localization

Outsourcing — up to 230 seats at peak.

Next steps

1. Prototype demo and GDD walkthrough — 60 minutes
2. Access to the full financial model and the betrayal matrix
3. Term sheet by the end of Q1 2027 — pre-production starts in summer